

Resource: Study Notes - Themes (Tyndale)

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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Study Notes - Themes (Tyndale)

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All Is "Vapor", Altars, Ancestors of Jesus, Ancient Law Codes, Angels, Anger, Apocalyptic Literature, Apostasy, Apostasy and Renewal, Atonement

All Is "Vapor"

A key word in the book of Ecclesiastes is the Hebrew term *hebel*. This word means "vapor." Often it is translated as "meaningless." This word captures the main view about life in this world of the Teacher. The Teacher, also called Qoheleth, is the main speaker in the book of Ecclesiastes.

The Hebrew word *hebel* means physical "breath" or "vapor." *Hebel* appears seventy-eight times in the Old Testament, but only three times does it obviously refer to the physical sense ([Psalm 62:9](#); [Proverbs 21:6](#); [Isaiah 57:13](#)). In the other seventy-five instances, it metaphorically describes what is hard to understand, futile, meaningless, false, temporary, or without substance.

The term often describes the lack of substance, lack of reality, and lack of worth of false gods ([Deuteronomy 32:21](#); [2 Kings 17:15](#)). In this sense, *hebel* is the opposite of "glory." God's glory is his presence that has substance, is weighty, and lasting. Sometimes, *hebel* represents how life is short and momentary, like vapor ([Job 7:16](#); [Psalm 144:4](#)). In other cases, it refers to the how meaningless and frustrating life can be ([Psalms 78:33](#); [94:11](#); [Isaiah 49:4](#)).

There is a long tradition of interpreting *hebel* in Ecclesiastes as meaning "vanity." This does not mean thinking too highly of oneself. But it refers to experiencing life as empty and without purpose. The ancient Greek translation of the Old Testament used the word *mataiotēs*, meaning "emptiness" or "futility."

The Latin Vulgate then translated *hebel* with the Latin word *vanitas*, which means "without purpose," "hollow," or "without worth." From the Vulgate comes the tradition of translating the word as "vanity" in English. Most translators today understand *hebel* to mean that life on earth seems

to have no clear purpose or meaning, and all that we do feels futile.

Some translators interpret *hebel* in Ecclesiastes as referring mainly to life's temporary nature. A vapor has no permanence or weight. This translation suggests a different view of Ecclesiastes. Life is not meaningless and futile, but rather not permanent and quickly ending. Many phrases in Ecclesiastes hint at the quick or short nature of human life and its efforts.

In the New Testament, a similar idea appears in [James 4:13–15](#). Understanding *hebel* as "not permanent" in Ecclesiastes helps explain the book plainly. But it is a less common view among scholars.

When reading Ecclesiastes, remember the root of the word is "breath" or "vapor," which supports the metaphors. The shortness and challenges of life can feel depressing. This should encourage us to work hard and wisely, and enjoy life while possible. We have all experienced life's unfair events, like a foolish person succeeding or unpunished injustice. These things make more sense when we remember God is in control. God will judge everything we do, including all secrets, whether good or bad ([Ecclesiastes 12:14](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 32:21](#); [2 Kings 17:15](#); [Job 7:16](#); [Psalms 62:9](#); [78:33](#); [94:11](#); [144:4](#); [Proverbs 21:6](#); [Ecclesiastes 1:2](#); [Isaiah 30:7](#); [49:4](#); [57:13](#)

Altars

Noah built the first altar mentioned in the Bible ([Genesis 8:20–21](#)). Cain and Abel also gave offerings to God ([Genesis 4:3–5](#)). The patriarchs built many altars (see [Genesis 12:7–8](#); [13:4](#), [18](#); [22:9](#); [26:25](#); [33:20](#); [35:1](#), [14–15](#)). These altars marked holy places where God revealed himself and personal land claims in the promised land.

These were both in the north (Shechem) and south (Beersheba).

They made altar of stone, earth, brick, or metal and wood. They were flat on top like a table, which helped the smoke rise. Altars were for memorials or used as places of sacrifice. They were the most common symbols of worship in the Old Testament and the ancient world.

Usually, an altar was on a raised platform with a ramp or stairs. This lifted the sacrifices for worship toward heaven. The four horns on the corners of many altars marked the holy area where the divine and human realms met (see [Exodus 27:2](#)). Through sacrifice and burning, the offering moved from the visible to the invisible world.

Jesus combines in himself the different symbolic roles of the high priest, sacrificial lamb, and altar (see [Hebrews 4:14–15](#); [7:24, 27](#); [9:14, 26](#); [10:10](#); [13:10, 12](#)). He prophesied his own sacrifice by mentioning the blood of martyrs (see [Matthew 23:35](#); [Luke 11:50–51](#)). His crucifixion represents the final sacrifice on "the altar" of the cross. Therefore, the "Lamb" who is seated as king in Revelation makes the temple and altar unnecessary ([Revelation 21:22](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 8:20–21](#); [12:7–8](#); [22:9–14](#); [33:20](#); [Exodus 20:24–26](#); [Joshua 22:10–34](#); [1 Kings 18:20–40](#); [Hosea 8:11–13](#); [Matthew 5:23–24](#); [Hebrews 13:10–14](#); [Revelation 6:9](#); [8:3–5](#)

Ancestors of Jesus

Both the Gospel of Matthew and the Gospel of Luke include a list of Jesus' ancestors ([Matthew 1:1–17](#); [Luke 3:23–38](#)). These lists are called "genealogies." The two genealogies are different after they mention King David. Matthew's list shows Jesus' family history through David's son King Solomon, while Luke's list shows Jesus' family history through David's son Nathan. Why are there two different lists? One possible explanation is that Matthew records Joseph's family history, while Luke records Mary's. In this case, Joseph would be Heli's son-in-law.

In ancient Jewish culture, people kept very careful records of their family histories. Josephus (a Jewish historian who lived in the first century AD) confirms this in his writings. Genealogies were important in the Old Testament and Judaism

because land rights were for families in Israel. Certain roles, like priest and king, passed from father to son.

Genealogies often showed connections from the past to the present. They emphasized religious themes, family descent, political ties, and simple timelines ([1 Chronicles 1–9](#)). Most genealogies listed important persons in the history of Israel. They were not a complete record of every family member.

Matthew and Luke each had different reasons for listing Jesus's ancestors. Matthew wanted to show that Jesus descended from Abraham through David. Matthew's genealogy confirms Jesus as a rightful heir to David's throne. Therefore, Matthew shows Jesus' ancestors back to Abraham, the father of the Jewish people. In contrast, Luke's genealogy lists Jesus' ancestors back to the first human, Adam. This aligns with Luke's focus on Jesus as the Savior for all people everywhere.

In Matthew's genealogy, it is notable that he mentions women. These women include Tamar, Rahab, Ruth, and Bathsheba. Some had bad reputations and some were non-Jews (gentiles). This emphasizes God's grace to redeem those whom others consider unworthy.

The genealogies of Jesus do not prove he is the Messiah (God's chosen one), but they do make him a possible candidate. His identity as the Messiah becomes clear in other ways ([Matthew 11:2–6](#)). God guided history to its climax. Jesus is the expected Messiah of the Old Testament. He is the savior of his people, and the king descended from David who takes his throne (see [2 Samuel 7:16](#)). Jesus is the heir to Abraham and ultimately fulfills God's promises to Abraham ([Genesis 12:1–3](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:1–3](#); [2 Samuel 7:16](#); [Matthew 1:1–17](#); [Luke 3:23–38](#)

Ancient Law Codes

Until the late 1800s, people thought the law of Moses was a unique legal code. They believed it existed nearly a thousand years before anything similar in Greek and Roman laws. Yet, archaeological excavations in Persia in the early 1900s uncovered the laws from the Babylonian king Hammurabi (called the Code of Hammurabi). He lived in the 1700s BC. This was several

centuries before the time traditionally associated with Moses.

Surprisingly, many of these laws are almost the same as those in the Bible. This suggested that biblical laws might have come from Hammurabi. But later discoveries found law codes that existed at least 500 years before Hammurabi. Several laws are common to all these codes, so Hammurabi was not the first to start them either.

What does this mean for the Bible?

1. It is not surprising to find similar laws in cultures near Israel. Similar societies need similar rules to ensure justice.
2. Biblical laws are unique because they are part of a covenant (special agreement) with God. In the ancient Near East, religious laws and civil laws were separate. Religious laws spoke of sacrifice, prayers, offerings, and others. Civil laws spoke of theft, lying, sexual conduct, murder, and others.

They considered ethics (rules about right and wrong) and religion to be different topics. Religion involved prayer, devotion, offerings, and ceremonies, managed by priests. Ethics dealt with social and civil behavior, managed by the king. The biblical view is different. God rules over both religion and society. So, a person in a relationship with the true God must worship properly and treat others well.

Israel's covenant with God used existing law forms but gave them new meaning. For example, the way God arranged Israel's tabernacle and temple was similar to others in the ancient world ([Exodus 26-27](#); see [1 Kings 6:1-7:51](#)). The Hebrew sacrifices were also similar to pagan sacrifices (see [Leviticus 1-7](#)). Yet, the temple and sacrifices had different meanings and purposes than those in paganism (see study notes on [Exodus 20:3-17](#); [25:1-40:38](#); [Leviticus 1:1-7:38](#)).

Many of the laws of Moses were not new to the ancient world. What was unique was that they came from the one Creator God, who called his people to live in a way that showed his character.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 20:1-23:33](#); [34:1-35:3](#); [Leviticus 1:1-27:34](#); [Deuteronomy 4:1-33:29](#); [Ezra 1:1-4](#); [Esther 1:13-19](#); [8:9-14](#); [Daniel 6:6-9](#); [Luke 2:1-3](#)

Angels

In the Bible, angels are God's messengers who carry out his plans and tell his will to humans ([Genesis 16:7-12](#); [Numbers 22:22-34](#); [Judges 13:3-21](#); [2 Kings 1:3, 15](#); [Zechariah 1:4-12](#)). The Hebrew Old Testament and Christian New Testament name only two angels, Michael and Gabriel, who have special tasks ([Daniel 8:16, 18](#); [9:21](#); [10:12, 21](#); [12:1-2](#); [Luke 1:19-20](#); [Jude 1:9](#)). Angels helped establish God's law through Moses ([Acts 7:30, 35, 38, 53](#); [Galatians 3:19](#)). They distribute God's grace and sometimes carry out his judgment ([2 Kings 19:35](#); [Acts 12:23](#); [Revelation 9:15](#); [16:1-12](#)).

Angels witnessed Christ's life and now witness the lives of God's people ([1 Timothy 3:16](#); [1 Corinthians 11:10](#); [1 Timothy 5:21](#)). Guardian angels protect God's people ([Matthews 18:10](#); see also [Psalms 34:7](#); [91:11](#); [Acts 12:11](#)). They are "spirits sent to serve those who will inherit salvation" ([Hebrews 1:14](#)). Angels will join Christ when he returns ([Matthew 25:31](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:7-8](#)). They will participate in the final judgment ([Matthew 13:39, 41, 49-50](#); [16:27](#); [24:31](#); [Mark 13:27](#); [Luke 9:26](#); [12:8](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:7](#)).

Angels appear at important moments in the gospels. They announced the births of John the Baptist and Jesus and served Jesus after his temptation ([Luke 1:1-2:52](#); [Matthew 4:11](#)). Angels also appeared at the empty tomb after Jesus' resurrection ([Matthew 28:1-8](#); [Mark 16:5-7](#); [Luke 24:23](#); [John 20:12](#)).

The role of angels is important in the book of Acts. Angels helped with miraculous prison escapes ([Acts 5:19](#); [12:6-11](#)). An angel encouraged Paul during a violent storm ([27:23-24](#)). An angel also told the Roman centurion (military officer) Cornelius to learn the gospel from Peter ([10:3, 7, 22](#); [11:13](#)). An angel struck down King Herod Agrippa because he accepted worship instead of giving glory to God ([12:23](#)). Throughout Acts, God guided his people and used angels to achieve his goals.

Some angels have sinned and will suffer eternal judgment ([Matthew 25:41](#); [2 Peter 2:4, 11](#); [Jude](#)

1:6). Angels are spiritual and heavenly beings, but they are inferior to Christ and must not be worshipped ([Galatians 1:8](#); [Colossians 2:18](#); [Hebrews 1:5-14](#); [Revelation 19:10](#); [22:8-9](#)). Only God must be worshipped ([Matthew 4:10](#); [Revelation 19:10](#); [22:8-9](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 91:11](#); [Daniel 8:15-18](#); [9:21-23](#); [10:4-11:1](#); [12:1-2](#); [Zechariah 1:8-13](#), [18-19](#); [2:3-5](#); [Matthew 1:20-24](#); [4:5-7](#), [11](#); [13:39-42](#), [49-50](#); [18:10](#); [24:31](#); [28:2-7](#); [Mark 16:5-7](#); [Luke 1:11-22](#), [26-38](#); [2:8-15](#); [9:26](#); [12:8](#); [John 20:12-13](#); [Acts 5:19-20](#); [7:30-35](#), [53](#); [10:3-8](#); [12:6-11](#), [23](#); [27:23-24](#); [1 Corinthians 11:10](#); [Galatians 1:8](#); [3:19](#); [Colossians 2:18](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:16](#); [1 Timothy 3:16](#); [5:21](#); [Hebrews 1:5-14](#); [12:22](#); [13:2](#); [2 Peter 2:4](#), [11](#); [Jude 1:6](#), [9](#); [Revelation 1:1-2](#); [5:2](#), [11-12](#); [7:1-2](#); [8:3-8](#); [9:15](#); [10:7-9](#); [14:6-10](#); [16:1-12](#); [19:10](#), [17](#); [20:1](#); [22:6-9](#)

Anger

Wise people do not get angry quickly. “A patient man has great understanding, but a quick-tempered man promotes folly” ([Proverbs 14:29](#)). Anger can cause bad judgment, so wise people think before they act ([14:16](#)).

The book of Proverbs views anger negatively, but not all anger in Scripture is bad. Many psalms speak of God's anger (for example, [Psalm 77](#)). Jesus was angry when he expelled the money changers from the temple ([Mark 11:15-17](#); [John 2:13-16](#)).

People must learn to tell the difference between righteous and unrighteous anger, though it is often difficult. Unrighteous anger focuses on protecting or promoting oneself (for example, [Genesis 4:3-8](#); [1 Samuel 18:8-9](#); [1 Kings 21:3-4](#); [2 Kings 5:11](#); [2 Chronicles 25:10](#); [Jonah 4](#)). Righteous anger shows God's hatred of evil and love of justice (for example, [Exodus 32](#); [Numbers 11:1](#), [10](#); see also [Nahum 1:3](#); [Romans 9:22](#)). A wise person understands the situation. Then that person decides if showing anger is appropriate (see also [Proverbs 22:24](#); [Ecclesiastes 7:9](#); [Matthew 5:22](#); [Romans 12:19](#); [Ephesians 4:26-27](#), [31](#); [James 1:19-20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 18:8-11](#); [1 Kings 21:3-16](#); [Psalms 30:5](#); [37:8](#); [Proverbs 12:16](#); [14:29](#); [15:1](#), [18](#); [16:14](#); [19:11-12](#), [19](#); [22:24-25](#); [27:4](#); [Ecclesiastes 7:9](#);

[Nahum 1:2-3](#); [Matthew 5:22](#); [Ephesians 4:26-27](#), [31-32](#); [1 Timothy 2:8](#); [Titus 1:7](#); [James 1:19-21](#)

Apocalyptic Literature

Several Old Testament passages have themes similar to later Jewish apocalyptic literature ([Isaiah 24-27](#); [Ezekiel 38:1-39:29](#); [Daniel 7-12](#); [Zechariah 9-14](#)). Apocalyptic literature is a kind of writing that uses visions and symbols to show God's final victory over evil and to give hope to his people. The entire book of Revelation in the New Testament also belongs to this genre.

Apocalyptic literature uses divine visions to communicate unclear or hidden things. The term *apocalyptic* comes from the Greek word *apokalupsis*, meaning “revelation.” But, other prophetic literature focuses on the words of the message. In legal terms, a prophet delivering a divine message (oracle) is like a prosecuting lawyer. A writer of apocalyptic literature is like a witness, describing the heavenly realities he has seen.

Prophecy usually predicts salvation or judgment within our current world. In contrast, apocalyptic literature expects a fulfillment beyond space and time. It does not hope for society to gradually improve. Instead, it prophesies a world-changing event that will end the way things are now and create something new. Apocalyptic literature views the present as a time of conflict between light and darkness. There can be no compromise or peace between the supernatural forces of good and evil.

Apocalyptic literature reveals the hidden elements of this battle. The presence of spiritual darkness becomes clear. This is also true of the unseen forces of good around us, which will ultimately win. This future victory is certain, regardless of any human or spiritual attempts to stop it.

Apocalyptic visions intend to encourage and motivate Christians, especially during difficult times. There is good news in these writings. Despite current hardships, God has already decided the final battle's outcome. The forces of good will win. Apocalyptic literature opposes pagan claims that things will stay the same. God rules and his kingdom will win in the end.

This message gives hope to believers during suffering. It urges them to stay faithful, despite challenges. It encourages those who struggle, affirming that God is in control and will ultimately

win. Despite suffering, obedience is the only way to live. We trust in the final victory when God will bring a new era of salvation.

Passages for Further Study

[Ezekiel 38:1-39:24](#); [Daniel 7:1-12:13](#); [Zechariah 9:1-14:21](#)

Apostasy

Sadly, opposition to God is not limited to those outside the community of faith. The Bible tells of many who seemed to know God but turned away (see [Numbers 16](#); [Deuteronomy 13](#); [2 Kings 17:5-23](#); [Ezekiel 8](#)). God brings fair consequences to those who turn away from him ([Job 11:20](#); [Proverbs 1:24-31](#); [Jeremiah 11:11](#)). Jesus spoke about those who "fall away" and the judgment they will receive ([Matthew 16:27](#); [23:13](#); [24:10-13](#); [25:41-46](#)). The New Testament writers follow his example ([Galatians 1:6-9](#); [2 Timothy 3:1-9](#); [2 Peter 2:1-22](#); [1 John 2:18-19](#)).

The Bible plainly states that disobeying God leads to severe consequences (see, for example, [Genesis 9:5-6](#); [Numbers 35:16-21](#); [Leviticus 20:10](#); [Zechariah 5:4](#)). God will eventually separate those who oppose his will and rule from his life-giving presence ([Isaiah 66:14-24](#)). In a similar way, several passages in the letter to the Hebrews warn those who do not take God's word seriously. It says that they will experience spiritual trouble and encounter God's judgment (see [Hebrews 2:1-4](#); [4:12-13](#); [6:4-8](#); [10:26-31](#); [12:25-29](#)).

Scholars interpret the "warning passages" in Hebrews about *apostasy* (falling away) and judgment in different ways:

1. Some think the warnings are suggestive. They are meant to arouse listeners from spiritual laziness, without referring to actual judgment.
2. Another view is that the author spoke of his concern about Jewish people who had not yet converted to Christianity. They were under God's judgment for not yet being part of the new covenant (God's new agreement or promise with humanity established through Jesus Christ).

3. A third perspective is that the "apostates" were Christians. Because of their spiritual state, they would encounter some of God's judgment. But, they were not at risk of losing their salvation.
4. A fourth view suggests the apostates were once full members of the Christian community. They had fully experienced the faith. But then turned away from Jesus and the church.
5. A fifth opinion is that the apostates were never true believers. This shows they never really knew Jesus from the start.

Warnings of judgment show God's grace. They intend to guide rebellious people back to God's ways. Understanding the consequences of turning away from the Christian faith can strengthen our commitment to follow Jesus faithfully.

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 16:1-50](#); [Deuteronomy 13:1-18](#); [2 Kings 17:5-23](#); [Ezekiel 8:1-18](#); [Matthew 24:10-13](#); [Galatians 1:6-9](#); [2 Timothy 3:1-9](#); [Hebrews 2:1-4](#); [6:4-8](#); [10:26-31](#); [2 Peter 2:1-22](#); [1 John 2:18-19](#)

Apostasy and Renewal

During the time of Israel's divided kingdom, people often considered the northern kingdom of Israel as unfaithful and the southern kingdom of Judah as faithful. When Jeroboam started the northern kingdom, many righteous people moved to Judah to avoid his wickedness ([2 Chronicles 11:13-17](#)). Yet, the southern kingdom eventually also turned away from faith in God.

King Ahaz became like Jeroboam:

1. He made metal idols ([28:2](#)).
2. He worshiped the gods of Damascus ([28:23](#)).
3. He neglected the temple ([28:24](#); [29:7](#), [19](#)).
4. He promoted false worship ([28:24-25](#)).

5. His unfaithfulness was so bad that the north had more righteousness than Judah at that time (see [28:9-15](#)).

The person who wrote the books of Chronicles wrote to inspire hope that God would restore Judah. He showed that God always forgives those who repent. Repentance can lead to restoration and reconciliation (making peace) with God. This was seen in the northern leaders' response to the prophet who confronted their victorious army ([28:8-15](#)).

Judah's renewal under King Hezekiah also was a model for restoration and unity, similar to King Solomon's rule. In the first year of his rule, Hezekiah began to restore the temple ([29:3](#)). When Hezekiah celebrated Passover, he invited people from the northern kingdom. This showed that both kingdoms could worship together at the place God had chosen ([30:18-20](#)). He temporarily restored the glory of Solomon's time ([30:26](#); compare [7:8-10](#)).

Israel's exile from the promised land did not end God's covenant community. Spiritual healing was always possible if the people chose to seek the LORD. This was true whether they returned with war spoils or reunited at the Passover feast. Many Old Testament prophets who warned rebellious Judah or Israel also spoke of future renewal and restoration.

The hope of renewal is also true for the church, even when encountering death by persecution (attacks because of their faith) or corruption (see [Revelation 2-3](#)). God's kingdom stands on the solid "rock" of his promises (see [Matthew 16:18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 21:1-29](#); [2 Chronicles 11:13-17](#); [28:1-31:21](#); [33:1-20](#); [Jeremiah 18:7-17](#); [Ezekiel 16:1-63](#); [33:10-16](#); [Joel 2:12-32](#); [Luke 19:2-10](#); [1 Corinthians 6:9-11](#); [1 Timothy 1:15-17](#)

Atonement

[Leviticus 16](#) explains the Day of Atonement. On this day, the high priest presented the community's sins to the LORD. Worshiping a holy God requires removing any ceremonial uncleanness or sin. God's grace accepted an animal's death instead of the sinner's life. In these offerings, the sacrifice represented the worshiper's life. They sacrificed the animal so the worshiper could live. Blood

represents life. God chose the blood of the sacrifice "that makes atonement" ([Leviticus 17:11](#)).

Atonement involves both *expiation* and *propitiation*. *Expiation* means paying what is owed. For example, the guilt offering involves damages or property loss, which must be repaid with a 20 percent extra charge ([5:14-6:7](#)). *Propitiation* means appeasing or reconciling with an offended person or group. For example, the whole burnt offering and the sin offering do not require a plain debt payment ([1:1-17](#); [4:1-5:13](#)).

In the atoning sacrifices that make peace with God, laying hands on the animal shows the worshiper's connection to the animal ([4:4-35](#); [16:21](#)). The blood represents the animal's life ([17:14](#)). It replaces the worshiper's life ([17:11](#)). They kill the animal, and offer to God its blood and certain parts in a ceremony. This cleanses and reconciles the worshiper with God.

The blood of Jesus provides atonement ([Ephesians 1:7](#); [Colossians 1:20](#)). It secures "eternal redemption" for Christians ([Hebrews 9:12](#)). Jesus, God's "Lamb," reconciles us with God ([John 1:29](#); [Hebrews 9:14](#)). He paid our sin debt (expiation) and satisfied God's judgment against sin (propitiation).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 25:17-22](#); [30:10-16](#); [Leviticus 1:1-17](#); [4:1-6:7](#); [16:1-34](#); [17:10-14](#); [23:26-32](#); [Numbers 15:22-29](#); [29:7-11](#); [Psalm 51:7](#); [Proverbs 16:6](#); [Ezekiel 43:18-27](#); [Daniel 9:24](#); [John 1:29](#); [Ephesians 1:7](#); [Colossians 1:20](#); [Hebrews 2:16-17](#); [9:12-14](#)